tions in real time, fostering transparency and accountability. The manual *pahani* (village land register) system, which had been reduced to a single column under Dharani, has been revived with 11 columns, ensuring detailed records for every land parcel. This addresses longstanding issues of incomplete and opaque record-keeping, which often left farmers at the mercy of bureaucratic red tape.

The introduction of mandatory survey maps for registrations is another important feature of Bhu Bharati. Similar to practices in neighbouring Karnataka, these maps provide a visual representation of land parcels, addressing the double-registration problem where unscrupulous individuals exploited discrepancies in record-keeping. The survey maps are being incorporated into land passbooks and village maps, creating a comprehensive system of cross-verification which will also make succession in landholding much simpler.

Decentralising Dispute Resolution

The new system also empowers the lower bureaucracy to tackle the grievances of farmers and other landowners. Though Dharani was introduced as a solution to all land-related problems, it had no redress mechanism for correcting the errors. This forced the aggrieved individuals to navigate a labyrinthine process, often ending up in civil courts where cases—unfortunately for most appellants—drag on for years. Bhu Bharati changes this. The government plans to empower mandal revenue officers (MROs) to register complaints using a dedicated mobile app, which will also allow those filing any petition to track its status. Additionally, a two-tier appellate mechanism and the establishment of special land tribunals will provide robust avenues for addressing more complex disputes.

"Lakhs of farmers will now find answers to their pending issues. The power to address grievances has been given back to tehsildars, revenue divisional officers and district collectors, so that people need not go to a civil court to find a resolution," says M. Sunil Kumar, an adjunct professor at the NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad, who is a member of the state agriculture commission and played a key role in drafting the new law. According to him, "for the first time in any land legislation in India", there is also provision for free legal aid to any aggrieved person "who is unable to appeal before the collector or land tribunal due to financial constraints".

BUREAUCRATIC BACKLOG

The Dharani portal, launched in 2020 to streamline land record management, instead left chaos in its wake

924,000
Title deed applications languishing unresolved

2.72 MN ACRES
Land put on prohibited list, barring transactions

1.83 MN ACRES
Land transactions on hold due to incomplete digital signatures

Even as the government worked out the modalities of the new law, it transferred Dharani's operations to the National Informatics Centre to restore public confidence

At a time when data breaches have become all too common, the reforms also focus on data integrity and privacy. Reddy, during the assembly debate, accused the previous system of fostering manipulation and corruption, alleging that "foreign entities" managed the portal and had unfettered access to sensitive data—Aadhaar details, mobile numbers and bank accounts—of landowners. So, even as the state government worked out the modalities of the new law, it transferred the management of Dharani from TerraCIS, the private agency previously responsible for it, to the NIC—a move aimed at leveraging this top government institution's expertise to restore public confidence and ensure that sensitive landowner information is handled securely and responsibly. A forensic audit of Dharani has also been ordered.

Mixed Response

The Opposition BRS leaders, however, have termed the reforms "counterproductive". "Replacing Dharani with Bhu Bharati is a betrayal of farmers," claims party legislator Palla Rajeshwar Reddy. "The Congress," he alleges, "is reviving outdated land practices, which will only benefit land grabbers and other criminals." But the real estate sector has largely welcomed the move. "The existing system is heavily centralised and inaccessible to landowners, especially farmers," says Vijaya Sai Meka, president, Telangana Real Estate Developers Association. "We appreciate the new multi-level appeal mechanism that will provide a speedy resolution to the problems genuine landowners face."

Still, some developers caution that further steps are needed to ensure the system's success. Comprehensive updates to village revenue and survey records, they argue, are vital to minimising disputes and reducing litigation in the long term. The government, on its part, has committed to periodic printing and preservation of land records, alongside dual record maintenance—manual and digital—to insulate against future challenges. If it is to be a panacea for all past ills, nothing short of that will do. ■